

SHUNNED? Kanwariyas walk past a shop with a new banner showing the owner's name in Muzaffarnagar, July 20

PTI

from real issues like inflation, unemployment and crimes against women."

FSDA officials, though, defend the UP government's decision. An official says, "The Supreme Court has clarified that the competent authority can issue orders under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 or the Street Vendors Act, 2014. The government only wants to prevent any kind of adulteration in food items by strengthening these laws." Section 56 of the Food Safety and Standards Act states that 'manufacturing or processing any food for human consumption under unhygienic conditions shall be liable to a fine of up to Rs 1 lakh'. If the adulteration leads to injury or death, the act provides for a punishment ranging from six months to life and a fine of Rs 1–10 lakh.

–Ashish Misra

THE SANGH ADVOCATES A 'SOCIALISATION' OF TEMPLES, NOT THEIR 'GOVERNMENTALISATION' TO RID THEM OF STATE CONTROL

on are Vaishno Devi in the Trikuta hills in J&K, Somnath in Gujarat, Kashi Vishwanath in Varanasi, and Jagannath in Puri, almost all of them in BJP-ruled states. There is also keen interest in the developments at the Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple in Thiruvananthapuram, where a Supreme Court ruling was in favour of the erstwhile Travancore royal family managing the temple affairs.

In a separate move, BJP maverick Subramanian Swamy has moved the apex court challenging the constitutional validity of Tamil Nadu's Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Act, 1959, under which the state has control over 4,000-odd temples. Andhra Pradesh deputy CM Kalyan has added another dimension to the controversy by suggesting that a national Sanatana Dharma Rakshana Board be set up. He has urged a nationwide debate involving all the stakeholders to address temple-related issues and "protect sanatana dharma from desecration".

With many of the big temples in the country now jittery about the purity of the prasad offerings, expect the courts to get busy dealing with the PILs. So aggrieved has the apex court been over the Tirupati laddoo affair that it asked whether it should order an independent investigation rather than let the central agencies handle it. The entire Tirupati laddoo controversy symbolises a worrying trend—that politicians will not spare even religious offerings for their divisive ends. An ominous portent. ■

with Anilesh S. Mahajan and Jumana Shah